student revision pack · Jan 2026 blueprint

ServiceNow

CSA Visual Study Notes

highly graphical · exam-weighted · sketchnote style

60	90	6	0
questions	minutes	domains	partial credit

COLOR LEGEND — MEMORIZE THIS PALETTE

- D1 teal 7% Platform
- D2 indigo 10% Instance
- D3 amber 20% Collaborate
- D4 rose 20% Self-service
- D5 violet 30% Data + security
- D6 sky 13% Logic + move

how to use these notes

Study **violet first** (Domain 5). Recite the yellow stickies out loud. Green boxes = do this on a PDI. Red boxes = classic traps. Then timed 50-question drill at the back.

not affiliated with ServiceNow · original study notes

The exam map

spend time where the points live

Official CSA Mainline blueprint (updated January 2026). Domains 3 + 4 + 5 = 70% of the paper.



DOMAIN 5 · 30%

Database + security

- Data schema / dictionary / sys_id
- ACLs (AND vs OR)
- Import Sets + **coalesce**
- CMDB + CSDM
- Security Center
- Shared Responsibility

DOMAIN 4 · 20%

Self-service + automation

Knowledge · Catalog · Workflow Studio · Virtual Agent

DOMAIN 3 · 20%

Collaboration

Lists · forms · save buttons · tasks · VTBs · reports · notifications

D6 · 13%

UI Policy · Business Rule · update sets · JavaScript

D2 · 10%

Plugins · branding · users/groups/roles · UIs

D1 · 7%

aPaaS · multi-instance · Next Experience chrome

⭐ **official sample answers (keep cold)**

Self-Service is for all users · **My Groups Work** · transform map = Import Set → existing table · variable types · language = **JavaScript**

STUDY SEQUENCE (NOT 1→6)

05 → 04 → 03 → 06 → 02 → 01

PDI: developer.servicenow.com · named update set always

map

01 · Platform & navigation

teal domain · 7% · vocabulary for everything else

What is ServiceNow?

Cloud **aPaaS** — they host it, you configure it.

Multi-instance (not classic multi-tenant DB). Each customer = dedicated app + database.

- Landscape: **PROD + DEV/TEST**
- **Clone** copies prod → subprod and overwrites the target
- **Now Support (HI)** = upgrades, some plugins, clones, cases
- **PDI** = free student instance + demo data

Who uses it?

persona	UI	role
End user	Portal / VA / Mobile	often no role
Fulfiller	Next Experience	`itil`
Admin	Native UI + Security Center	`admin`
Sec admin	ACLs	`security_admin` ↑

✏️ **sample item**

Self-Service is available to ALL users. Incident / Change need roles.

Next Experience chrome — sketch this from memory

```
+---------------- BANNER FRAME ------------------+
| logo   global search    help    user menu      |
+--------+-----------------------------------+
|  NAV   |           CONTENT FRAME           |
| All    |  lists · forms · dashboards       |
| ★ Fav  |  VTBs · reports · workspaces      |
| Hist   |                                   |
| filter |                                   |
+--------+-----------------------------------+
```

Logo click = home
`cache.do` = flush cache
`incident.list` = open list

Impersonate = test as them
Elevate = `security_admin` this session only

Personalization = gear, you
Customization = logo, everyone

Now Mobile = iOS + Android · History ≠ audit log

02 · Instance configuration

indigo domain · 10% · make the instance yours

Plugins

All → System Definition → Plugins. Some need Now Support. Some **cannot be undone** — sub-prod first. Guided Setup = empty circle not started.

Branding

Logo, tab title, colors, theme = **customization** (update set). Gear settings = **personalization** (not captured).

Properties

`sys_properties.list`. Homepages deprecated → dashboards. After change: new session or `cache.do`.

Users · Groups · Roles — the golden chain

ROLES permissions → sit on **GROUPS** sys_user_group → contain **USERS** sys_user

⚠️ **don't**

Assign roles directly to every user. Deleting users who own history. Developing in production.

⭐ **do**

Deactivate users (`active=false`). Roles contain roles (inheritance). Impersonate after every permission change.

Role cheat chips

admin · itil · snc_internal · approver_user · catalog_admin · knowledge_admin · import_admin · security_admin ↑ · flow_designer · report_publisher · personalize_form

Can't see a module?

1. Application menu **role**
2. Module **role**
3. Table **ACL** (different layer!)

Gear on list
my columns · green dot · personalization

VS

Configure → List Layout
everyone on that **view** · customization

Number Maintenance sets INC/CHG prefixes · High Security needs elevate for ACLs

03 · Collaboration — lists & forms

amber domain · 20% · 'what happens when I click X'

List anatomy

- Row = record · Column = field
- Breadcrumbs = the filter
- Filter = Field + Operator + Value
- Right-click menus: title / column / cell / row / form
- Double-click cell = list edit (if allowed)
- Tags ≠ categories ≠ user criteria

Form anatomy

- Header buttons · sections · fields
- Related lists (children pointing here)
- Activity stream + User Presence
- Reference field stores `sys_id`, shows name
- **Dot-walk**: Caller → Department → Name
- **View** = named layout (Default ≠ Self Service)

The save-button board (write this on your exam scrap paper)

action	new record?	form closes?	when
Submit	NEW record	YES — closes	creating
Update	same record	YES — closes	existing
Save	same (or first insert)	NO — stays	keep working
Insert	NEW sys_id (clone values)	YES	form menu
Insert and Stay	NEW sys_id	NO — stays	form menu

⚠️ **Insert ≠ Submit**
Insert from an **existing** record clones it into a new row. Update ≠ Save (close vs stay).

comments vs work notes
Additional comments = caller can see (and often gets emailed).
Work notes = fulfiller only.

missing field?
Check **view** first, then UI Policy, then field ACL, then dictionary. Don't jump to ACL every time.

Form Designer = canvas · Form Layout = slushbucket · same result

03 · Tasks, VTBs, reports, mail

still amber · still 20%

Task table is the parent

`incident` / `problem` / `change_request` / `sc_request` / `sc_req_item` / `sc_task` all **extend** `task`.

My Work	assigned to **me**
My Groups Work	assigned to **my group**, usually nobody yet

> ✏️ **official wording**
> The module is **My Groups Work** — not My Teams Work / Tasks.

Clocks on a task

SLA	you ↔ customer
OLA	internal teams
UC	you ↔ supplier
Inactivity	nobody touched it — not a contract

SLA life: **Start** **Pause** **Stop** · table `task_sla`

Visual Task Boards

Guided
lanes = a field (State). Drag **updates the record**.

Flexible
field lanes + extra lanes you add.

Freeform
you invent lanes. Does **not** reliably change Incident State.

Report Designer tabs

Data → **Type** → **Configure** → **Style**

Recommended share method = **Share** (users/groups/roles). Publish = public-ish URL. Dashboards replace homepages.

Notifications = 3 tabs

When → **Who** → **What**

Usually fired by a **system event**. Users subscribe in System Settings. Inbound email can **create/update** a record.

Assignment rules: System Policy → Rules → Assignment

04 · Self-service & automation

rose domain · 20% · let employees help themselves

1. Search / chat
Portal, Employee Center, Virtual Agent, Now Mobile

2. Knowledge?
How-to article. If published + user criteria match → no ticket.

3. Need something done?
Catalog item or record producer → Flow fulfills it.

Catalog family tree (draw this in the exam)

REQ `sc_request · cart` → **RITM** `sc_req_item · each item` → **SCTASK** `sc_task · fulfillers`

2 items in one cart = 1 REQ + 2 RITMs. Record producer skips this and writes Incident (or another table) directly.

Item types

Catalog Item	order → REQ/RITM/SCTASK
Record Producer	creates a row on a **target table**
Order Guide	many items, one request
Content Item	link / knowledge — not an order

Multiple Choice, Single Line Text, Select Box = **variable types** (official sample). Variable **sets** = reuse.

Knowledge

Draft → Review → **Published** (searchable) → Retired.

Can Read vs **Can Contribute** user criteria are separate.

> ⚠️ **invisible article?**
> Not published, or user criteria blocked the reader. Impersonate an ESS user to test.

Always attach a Flow to catalog items or nobody fulfills them — D4a

04 · Workflow Studio + Virtual Agent

rose continued

WORKFLOW STUDIO IS THE UMBRELLA NAME ON THE 2026 BLUEPRINT

Flow Designer
trigger + actions + wait

PAD / Playbooks
cross-enterprise agent stages

Workflow Editor
legacy graph — don't start new here

A flow

Trigger → **Actions** → **if / wait / for each**

Triggers: record · date · Service Catalog · inbound email · SLA task.

Core actions: Create/Update Record, Ask for Approval, Create Catalog Task, Send Email, Look Up, Subflow.

Roles: `flow_designer` · `action_designer` · `flow_operator`

Flow CAN wait
approval for 2 days, timer, inbound

Business Rule CANNOT wait
same database transaction. Use for set-field-on-save.

Virtual Agent

Talks to **Knowledge + Catalog + records**

Lives on portal, mobile, **Teams / Slack**

Can hand off to a **live agent**

💡 **CSA depth**
You will not build an NLU model. You must know VA is a self-service channel equal to portal search.

test mantra
Impersonate a user with **no itil role** after every catalog / knowledge / VA change.

Spoke = bundle of Flow actions (often an integration)

05 · Data schema

violet domain · 30% · if you only master one chapter, this one

Everything is a record in a table

Base	`task`, `cmdb`
Child / extend	`incident` **is-a** task
Custom global	`u_...`
Scoped app	`x_company_app_...`

sys_id = 32-char GUID (real key). Number like INC0001 is just a label.

How tables relate

- **Extension** — Extends table field
- **One-to-many** — reference field on the many side (Incident.caller → User)
- **Many-to-many** — join table (task_ci)

Visualize with the Schema Map (Tables & Columns). Dictionary = field metadata. **Dictionary override** = change a parent field on a **child only**.

ACL sketchnote

`incident`	`incident.*`	`incident.work_notes`
row / table (.None)	fields in general	that one field

ONE acl record = AND

Roles **and** condition **and** script must all pass (empty parts skipped).

SEVERAL acls at same spot = OR

Pass **any one** matching rule at that level.

table ACL first → **then field ACL** → **table.field beats table.***

> ⚠️ **no ACL + High Security default deny**
> Access is **denied**. UI Policy hiding a field is **not** security. Elevate `security_admin` to create ACLs.

Dot-walk with the green + in condition builders

05 · Import, CMDB, CSDM, security

violet continued — the rest of the 30%

Import Sets

Excel / CSV / JDBC / LDAP → staging table → Transform Map → target table

official definition
A transform map relates **Import Set fields** to fields on an **existing table**.

coalesce
Match key → **UPDATE**. No match → insert. No coalesce → **duplicates**. Use email / employee # / serial.

💡 **UI Policy vs import**
UI Policies do **not** run on transform. Use a **Data Policy** (or dictionary mandatory) if Excel must obey the rule.

CMDB + CSDM

`cmdb_ci`
configuration items (tangible + intangible)

`cmdb_rel_ci`
relationships · Dependency Views

CI Class Manager
classes, identity, hierarchy

Discovery = bottom-up, needs MID Server in your network.
Service Mapping = top-down from a service entry point.
CSDM = common vocabulary / best-practice model — not "a plugin that replaces ITSM".

Foundation users/locations (usually not CI relationships)
Design Business Application
Manage tech Application Service + infra CIs
Sell/Consume Business Service + catalog
Catalog is **not a CMDB table**

ServiceNow owns
data centers, platform software, instance isolation, cloud ops

VS

You own
users, roles, ACLs, what data you store, MID Servers, acting on Security Center

Security Center = instance security *posture* dashboard — not Security Incident Response, not firewall CIs.

Business Application (design) ≠ Application Service (deployed instance you incident against)

06 · Logic & moving config

sky domain · 13% · which tool, and how it travels

DECISION TREE — PICK THE MOST SPECIFIC NO-CODE TOOL THAT FITS

need	tool
Mandatory / visible / read-only **on the form**	**UI Policy** (client)
Same rule on **import / API / list edit**	**Data Policy** (server)
Wait for approval / timer	**Flow** (Workflow Studio)
Set a field during save / abort	**before Business Rule**
Slow / external	async BR or Flow + spoke
Browser script / onChange / onSubmit	**Client Script**
Stop unauthorized access	**ACL** — never UI Policy
Move configuration DEV→TEST	**Update set** / app install
Move 10,000 users	**Import Set**

Business Rule timings

before	validate, set fields, abort, query filter
after	other records / events — keep short
async	queued, slow work
display	`g_scratchpad` for the client

Client vs server APIs

Client: `g_form g_user g_scratchpad`
Server: `current previous gs GlideRecord`

> ✏️ **language**
> The platform is scripted in **JavaScript** — not Java, not Jelly.

GlideRecord inside a Client Script = performance trap. Use GlideAjax + Script Include.

Update set lifecycle

named set → **do work** → **Complete** → **Preview** → **Commit**

> ⚠️ **Default update set**
> Never migrate Default. Update sets capture **config**, not incident/user/CMDB data. Clone = whole instance.

Client Script types: onLoad · onChange · onSubmit · onCellEdit

Wall of comparisons

if two answers look right, this page decides

Personalize	one user · gear · favorites
Customize	instance · form layout · BR · logo

Module role	sees the menu item
ACL	sees the record / field
User criteria	sees catalog / knowledge

Knowledge	how-to · no REQ chain
Catalog item	REQ → RITM → SCTASK
Record producer	writes target table
Order guide	many items, one REQ

Update set	configuration
Import Set	data + transform map
Clone	whole instance overwrite
Scoped app	versioned install

CMDB	CIs + relationships
CSDM	how to use those classes
Discovery	bottom-up + MID
Service Mapping	top-down

AuthN	who are you? local/LDAP/SSO
AuthZ	what may you do? roles/ACLs
Elevate	security_admin this session
Impersonate	test as another user

⭐ **exam heuristic**

When both could work, pick the **most specific platform feature**: UI Policy before Client Script · Data Policy if server-side · Flow if it must wait · ACL if it is about access.

PDI lab checklist

green boxes = do, don't just read

Request a Personal Developer Instance. Create update set `CSA Workbook Labs`.

1. Navigator, impersonate Abel Tuter, `incident.list`
2. Role → group → user (no roles on the user record)
3. Filter + save for a group · gear vs Configure layout
4. Insert and Stay — prove a new number
5. Guided VTB on Incident State
6. Notification When / Who / What
7. Publish a knowledge article, impersonate ESS, retire it
8. Catalog item + flow (approval + SCTASK) → REQ/RITM/SCTASK
9. Record producer → Incident (no REQ)

10. Custom table + Schema Map + related list
11. Elevate · table ACL · field ACL · impersonate
12. CSV import, coalesce email, run twice
13. CI Class Manager + Dependency View
14. Open Security Center · write 5 shared-responsibility bullets
15. UI Policy vs Data Policy vs before BR vs Client Script
16. Complete update set · export XML · Preview
17. **Capstone:** article + catalog flow + producer + report + ACL

🧪 **capstone pass bar**

If you can demo the employee path in 15 minutes (ESS user + fulfiller), you are operationally ready for CSA scenarios.

Exam-day method

- First pass < 45 min · flag the rest
- Multi-select: select **exactly N** — miss one = zero
- No blanks (no penalty for guessing)
- Confirm the **exam release** on docs.servicenow.com

50 practice answers — drill sheet

original items · not live exam dumps · 90 min, no partial credit

Cover the stem, answer, then check. Full stems live in the markdown workbook Chapter 09.

1. B multi-instance
2. D Self-Service
3. A banner / nav / content
4. B Impersonate
5. B roles → groups → users
6. B personalization
7. C security_admin
8. C dashboards
9. B field + operator + value
10. D Insert and Stay
11. B My Groups Work
12. A+C Guided + owner
13. B Share
14. B system events
15. A caller-visible comments
16. B user criteria
17. B 1 REQ, 2 RITMs
18. C variable types
19. B producer → target table
20. B order guide = many items
21. C Flow can wait
22. B knowledge + catalog + records
23. A Flow Designer + PAD
24. B sys_id
25. B extension
26. B one-to-many reference
27. B Schema Map
28. A dictionary override
29. B ACL parts AND
30. B field hidden, record opens
31. B default deny
32. A transform map def
33. B coalesce email
34. A+B cmdb_ci + cmdb_rel_ci
35. B CSDM = model / vocab
36. B MID inside your network
37. B customer owns ACLs
38. B Security Center = posture
39. B UI Policy
40. B Data Policy
41. B display BR → g_scratchpad
42. B flows wait, BRs don't
43. C JavaScript
44. B update sets = config
45. B Preview then Commit
46. B named update set
47. B g_form is client
48. B UI Policy ≠ security
49. B catalog ≠ CMDB table
50. B missing module role

Target: 45+/50 before you book Pearson.

Pocket glossary + shortcuts

last-week skim

TYPE THESE IN THE FILTER

```
incident.list
sys_user.list · sys_user_group.list
sys_script.list   ← Business Rules
sys_script_client.list
sys_ui_policy.list
sys_security_acl.list
sys_update_set.list
sys_properties.list
cmdb_ci.list · cmdb_rel_ci.list
kb_knowledge.list · sc_cat_item.list
task_sla.list
cache.do
```

Can't see module → app/module role
Can't see record → table ACL / query BR
Can't see field → view → UI Policy → field ACL
Duplicates → coalesce missing
Missing from update set → Default set, or it's data

Keep current: annual delta exam + CMP fee. Next paths: CIS-ITSM, CAD, CSDM / Data Foundations.

MID
Management, Instrumentation, Discovery — on-network worker

IRE
Identification & Reconciliation — stops duplicate CIs

HI
Now Support portal for instance ops

aPaaS
Application Platform as a Service

you've got this.

Original study notes based on the public CSA exam specification. Confirm details on docs.servicenow.com for your exam release.